
Spanish Tourist Guide

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1 Spanish Communication Guide

1.0.1 Practical Phrases for Everyday Interactions in Spain & Latin America

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1.1 About This Guide

This guide focuses on **practical communication** — the phrases and patterns you need for real conversations in Spanish-speaking countries. Rather than tourism tips, you'll find scenario-based phrases organized for quick reference, with tables showing both fixed expressions and reusable pattern templates. Where Spain and Latin America differ, both variants are provided side by side.

1.2 Who This Guide Is For

- Travelers who want to communicate confidently in Spanish-speaking countries
- Anyone interacting with hotel staff, shop clerks, restaurant workers, and locals
- People who prefer learning through practical scenarios over grammar theory
- Those who want both ready-to-use phrases and customizable patterns

1.3 What's Inside

- **Pattern phrase templates:** Reusable structures like “Could you please [action]?” with example slots
- **Scenario-based phrases:** Organized by situation (greetings, restaurants, hotels, shopping, transport, emergencies)
- **Communication tables:** Quick-scan format showing English, Spanish, pronunciation, and usage notes
- **Politeness tiers:** Informal (tú), Formal (usted), and Regional (vos/vosotros) options
- **Regional variations:** Spain vs. Latin America differences where relevant
- **Cultural context:** Communication etiquette and notes where they affect phrasing

1.4 How to Use This Guide

1. **Start with Core Phrases** (Chapter 1) for essential patterns and greetings
2. **Jump to scenario chapters** when you need phrases for a specific situation
3. **Use the pattern templates** to create new phrases by swapping words
4. **Check politeness levels** to match the situation (staff = usted, friends = tú)
5. **Reference pronunciation and writing** chapters for deeper understanding

1.5 Guide Structure

1.5.1 Part 1: Core Communication

- **Chapter 1: Core Phrases** — Pattern templates, greetings, small talk, asking for help, emergencies

1.5.2 Part 2: Language Foundations

- **Chapter 2: Language Foundations** — Essential grammar, gendered nouns, ser/estar, verb conjugation
- **Chapter 3: Pronunciation** — Vowels, consonants, stress rules, regional accents
- **Chapter 4: Writing Systems** — Alphabet, accent marks, special characters, typing tips

1.5.3 Part 3: Scenario-Based Phrases

- **Chapter 5: Directions & Navigation** — Asking directions, landmarks, getting around
- **Chapter 6: Transportation** — Trains, buses, taxis, airports, transport cards
- **Chapter 7: Restaurants** — Ordering, dietary needs, payment, tipping
- **Chapter 8: Shopping** — Sizes, trying on, payment, bargaining
- **Chapter 9: Hotels** — Check-in/out, requests, problems, accommodation types

1.5.4 Part 4: Cultural Context

- **Chapter 10: Cultural Guide** — Regional differences, etiquette, safety

1.6 Key Features

1.6.1 Pattern Phrases (Templates)

This guide emphasizes **pattern phrases** — templates you can customize:

Pattern	Spanish	Example
[thing] please	[cosa] por favor	Agua por favor = Water please
Can I [action]?	¿Puedo [infinitive]?	¿Puedo pagar con tarjeta? = Can I pay by card?
Where is [place]?	¿Dónde está [lugar]?	¿Dónde está el baño? = Where is the bathroom?

1.6.2 Phrase Tables

All phrases use clear **table format** for quick scanning:

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Thank you	Gracias	GRAH-syahs	Universal
Excuse me	Disculpe	dees-KOOL-peh	Getting attention (formal)

1.6.3 Politeness Levels

Each section indicates appropriate **formality**: - **Informal (tú)** — Friends, young people, casual settings - **Formal (usted)** — Strangers, older people, service staff - **Regional (vos)** — Argentina, Uruguay, parts of Central America - **Regional (vosotros)** — Spain only (plural informal)

1.7 A Note on Regional Variation

Spanish is spoken across over 20 countries, and each has its own flavor. This guide covers the two major branches — **Spain (Peninsular Spanish)** and **Latin America** — giving both forms wherever they differ significantly. Within Latin America, we highlight Mexican and Argentine variants as the most widely encountered.

Don't worry about getting the "wrong" Spanish — speakers everywhere appreciate the effort and will understand you regardless of which variant you use.

1.8 Begin Your Journey

¡Bienvenido al mundo hispanohablante! **Welcome to the Spanish-speaking world!**

This guide is a living document focused on practical communication for everyday interactions.

2 Core Communication Phrases

This chapter provides essential phrases for everyday interactions in Spanish-speaking countries, organized by communication scenario. Each section includes **pattern phrases** (templates with slots you can fill in) and **fixed phrases** (ready-to-use expressions).

2.1 Pattern Phrase Templates

These reusable patterns let you express many ideas by swapping words in the slots marked with [brackets].

2.1.1 Requesting Something

Pattern	Spanish	Pronunciation	Example
[thing] please	[cosa] por favor	[KO-sah] por fah-BOR	Agua por favor = Water please
I would like [thing]	Quisiera [cosa]	kee-SYEH-rah [KO-sah]	Quisiera un café = I would like a coffee
Could you please [action]?	¿Podría [infinitivo]?	poh-DREE-ah [inf.]	¿Podría repetir? = Could you please repeat?
I need [thing]	Necesito [cosa]	neh-seh-SEE-toh [KO-sah]	Necesito ayuda = I need help
I want [thing]	Quiero [cosa]	KYEH-roh [KO-sah]	Quiero la cuenta = I want the bill
Please [action]	Por favor, [imperativo]	por fah-BOR [imp.]	Por favor, espere = Please wait

2.1.2 Asking Permission

Pattern	Spanish	Pronunciation	Example
Can I [action]?	¿Puedo [infinitivo]?	PWEH-doh [inf.]	¿Puedo sentarme aquí? = Can I sit here?
May I [action]?	¿Me permite [infinitivo]?	meh pehr-MEE-teh [inf.]	¿Me permite pasar? = May I pass?
Is it okay if I [action]?	¿Está bien si [presente]?	ehs-TAH byehn see [pres.]	¿Está bien si fumo? = Is it okay if I smoke?

2.1.3 Asking Questions

Pattern	Spanish	Pronunciation	Example
Where is [place]?	¿Dónde está [lugar]?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH [loo-GAR]	¿Dónde está el baño? = Where is the bathroom?
How do I get to [place]?	¿Cómo llego a [lugar]?	KOH-moh YEH-goh ah [loo-GAR]	¿Cómo llego al centro? = How do I get to downtown?
Do you have [thing]?	¿Tiene [cosa]?	TYEH-neh [KO-sah]	¿Tiene menú en inglés? = Do you have an English menu?
What is [thing]?	¿Qué es [cosa]?	keh ehs [KO-sah]	¿Qué es esto? = What is this?
How much is [thing]?	¿Cuánto cuesta [cosa]?	KWAHN-toh KWEHS-tah [KO-sah]	¿Cuánto cuesta esto? = How much is this?
What time does [place] [action]?	¿A qué hora [verbo] [lugar]?	ah keh OH-rah [BEHR-boh]	¿A qué hora cierra la tienda? = What time does the store close?

2.1.4 Stating Preferences and Needs

Pattern	Spanish	Pronunciation	Example
I don't eat [food]	No como [comida]	noh KOH-moh [koh-MEE-dah]	No como carne = I don't eat meat
I'm allergic to [thing]	Soy alérgico/a a [cosa]	soy ah-LEHR-hee-koh ah [KO-sah]	Soy alérgico a los mariscos = I'm allergic to shellfish
Without [thing] please	Sin [cosa] por favor	seen [KO-sah] por fah-BOR	Sin cebolla por favor = Without onion please
I'm looking for [thing]	Estoy buscando [cosa]	ehs-TOY boos-KAHN-doh [KO-sah]	Estoy buscando el hotel = I'm looking for the hotel

2.2 Greetings and Basic Courtesies

2.2.1 Daily Greetings

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	When to Use
Good morning	Buenos días	BWEH-nohs DEE-ahs	Until ~12 PM
Good afternoon	Buenas tardes	BWEH-nahs TAHR-dehs	~12 PM - 8 PM
Good evening/night	Buenas noches	BWEH-nahs NOH-chehs	After ~8 PM
Hello	Hola	OH-lah	Any time, casual
Hi, how are you?	¡Hola! ¿Qué tal?	OH-lah keh tahl	Casual greeting

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	When to Use
How are you? (formal)	¿Cómo está usted?	KOH-moh ehs-TAH oos-TEHD	Formal
Goodbye	Adiós	ah-DYOHS	Standard farewell
See you later	Hasta luego	AHS-tah LWEH-goh	Common, any formality
See you tomorrow	Hasta mañana	AHS-tah mah-NYAH-nah	Same as English
See you soon	Hasta pronto	AHS-tah PROHN-toh	Friendly parting

2.2.2 Thank You Expressions

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Formality
Thanks	Gracias	GRAH-syahs	Universal
Thank you very much	Muchas gracias	MOO-chahs GRAH-syahs	Warmer
Thank you so much	Muchísimas gracias	moo-CHEE-see-mahs GRAH-syahs	Very grateful
I really appreciate it	Se lo agradezco mucho	seh loh ah-grah-DEHS-koh MOO-choh	Formal

2.2.3 Apologies and Excusing Yourself

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	When to Use
Excuse me (attention)	Disculpe	dees-KOOL-peh	Getting attention (formal)
Excuse me (passing)	Permiso / Con permiso	pehr-MEE-soh / kon pehr-MEE-soh	Passing through a crowd
Sorry	Lo siento	loh SYEHN-toh	Apology
I'm very sorry	Lo siento mucho	loh SYEHN-toh MOO-choh	Stronger apology
Pardon?	¿Perdón? / ¿Cómo?	pehr-DOHN / KOH-moh	Didn't hear/understand

2.2.4 Responding to Thanks

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Formality
You're welcome	De nada	deh NAH-dah	Standard
Don't mention it	No hay de qué	noh eye deh keh	Slightly more formal
It's nothing	No es nada	noh ehs NAH-dah	Casual
My pleasure	Con mucho gusto	kon MOO-choh GOOS-toh	Warm, polite

2.3 Meeting People and Small Talk

2.3.1 Introductions

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Nice to meet you	Mucho gusto	MOO-choh GOOS-toh	Standard, all situations
Nice to meet you (formal)	Encantado/Encantada	ehn-kahn-TAH-doh/dah	-o = male speaker, -a = female
I'm [name]	Soy [nombre]	soy [NOHM-breh]	Stating your name
My name is [name]	Me llamo [nombre]	meh YAH-moh [NOHM-breh]	More formal
Where are you from?	¿De dónde eres/es?	deh DOHN-deh EH-rehs/ehs	eres = tú, es = usted
I'm from [country]	Soy de [país]	soy deh [pah-EES]	Stating origin
What do you do?	¿A qué te/se dedica?	ah keh teh/seh deh-DEE-kah	te = tú, se = usted

2.3.2 Small Talk Questions

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Is this your first time here?	¿Es tu/su primera vez aquí?	ehs too/soo pree-MEH-rah behs ah-KEE	tu = tú, su = usted
How long are you staying?	¿Cuánto tiempo te/se queda?	KWAHN-toh TYEHM-poh teh/seh KEH-dah	Common question
Are you traveling alone?	¿Viaja solo/sola?	BYAH-hah SOH-loh/SOH-lah	-o = male, -a = female
Do you like [place]?	¿Le/Te gusta [lugar]?	leh/teh GOOS-tah [loo-GAR]	Le = usted, Te = tú

2.3.3 Small Talk Responses

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Yes, first time	Sí, es mi primera vez	see ehs mee pree-MEH-rah behs	First visit
No, I've been here before	No, ya he estado aquí antes	noh yah eh ehs-TAH-doh ah-KEE AHN-tehs	Return visit
For [X] days	Por [X] días	por [X] DEE-ahs	Duration
I'm on vacation	Estoy de vacaciones	ehs-TOY deh bah-kah-SYOH-nehs	Tourism
For work	Por trabajo	por trah-BAH-hoh	Business
I love it here	Me encanta este lugar	meh ehn-KAHN-tah EHS-teh loo-GAR	Positive response

2.4 Asking for Help

2.4.1 Getting Attention

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Context
Excuse me	Disculpe	dees-KOOL-peh	Standard, formal
Excuse me (casual)	Oye / Oiga	OH-yeh / OY-gah	Casual / Semi-formal

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Context
Hello? (service counter)	¿Hola? / ¿Buenos días?	OH-lah / BWEH-nohs DEE-ahs	At counters

2.4.2 Requesting Assistance

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Formality
Can you help me?	¿Puede ayudarme?	PWEH-deh ah-yoo-DAHR-meh	Formal
Can you help me? (casual)	¿Me puedes ayudar?	meh PWEH-dehs ah-yoo-DAHR	Informal
Please help me	Ayúdeme por favor	ah-YOO-deh-meh por fah-BOR	Urgent, formal
Help!	¡Ayuda!	ah-YOO-dah	Emergency
I need help	Necesito ayuda	neh-seh-SEE-toh ah-YOO-dah	Stating need
I'm lost	Estoy perdido/perdida	ehs-TOY pehr-DEE-doh/dah	-o = male, -a = female
I have a problem	Tengo un problema	TEHN-goh oon proh-BLEH-mah	Explaining situation

2.4.3 Communication Difficulties

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I don't understand	No entiendo	noh ehN-TYEHN-doh	Very useful
I don't speak Spanish	No hablo español	noh AH-bloh ehs-pah-NYOHL	Explaining
Do you speak English?	¿Habla inglés?	AH-blah een-GLEHS	Asking for English
Please speak slowly	Por favor, hable más despacio	por fah-BOR AH-bleh mahs dehs-PAH-syoh	Request slower speech
Please say that again	¿Puede repetir, por favor?	PWEH-deh reh-peh-TEER por fah-BOR	Ask for repetition
Please write it down	¿Puede escribirlo?	PWEH-deh ehs-kree-BEER-loh	Very helpful
What does [word] mean?	¿Qué significa [palabra]?	keh seeg-NEE-fee-kah [pah-LAH-brah]	Learning vocabulary
How do you say [word]?	¿Cómo se dice [palabra]?	KOH-moh seh DEE-seh [pah-LAH-brah]	Asking for translation

2.5 Emergencies

2.5.1 Urgent Phrases

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Help!	¡Ayuda!	ah-YOO-dah	Shout for help
Emergency!	¡Emergencia!	eh-mehr-HEHN-syah	Urgent situation
Call the police!	¡Llame a la policía!	YAH-meh ah lah poh-lee-SEE-ah	Spain: 112, Mexico: 911

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Call an ambulance!	¡Llame una ambulancia!	YAH-meh OO-nah ahm-boo-LAHN-syah	Spain: 112, Mexico: 911
Fire!	¡Fuego! / ¡Incendio!	FWEH-goh / een-SEHN-dyoh	Fire emergency
Stop!	¡Pare! / ¡Alto!	PAH-reh / AHL-toh	Command to stop
Thief!	¡Ladrón!	lah-DROHN	If robbed

2.5.2 Medical Emergencies

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I need a doctor	Necesito un médico	neh-seh-SEE-toh oon MEH-dee-koh	Medical need
Where is the hospital?	¿Dónde está el hospital?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH ehl ohs-pee-TAHL	Finding hospital
I'm sick	Estoy enfermo/enferma	ehs-TOY ehn-FEHR-moh/mah	Feeling unwell
It hurts here	Me duele aquí	meh DWEH-leh ah-KEE	Point to location
I need medicine	Necesito medicinas	neh-seh-SEE-toh meh-dee-SEE-nahs	Need medication
I have [condition]	Tengo [condición]	TEHN-goh [kohn-dee-SYOHN]	Stating condition
I'm diabetic	Soy diabético/a	soy dyah-BEH-tee-koh/kah	Important medical info
I take [medication]	Tomo [medicamento]	TOH-moh [meh-dee-kah-MEHN-toh]	Current medication

2.5.3 Lost and Stolen

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I lost my [item]	Perdí mi [cosa]	pehr-DEE mee [KO-sah]	Lost item
[Item] was stolen	Me robaron [cosa]	meh roh-BAH-rohn [KO-sah]	Theft
Where is the police station?	¿Dónde está la comisaría?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH lah koh-mee-sah-REE-ah	Find police station
I want to file a report	Quiero poner una denuncia	KYEH-roh poh-NEHR OO-nah deh-NOON-syah	File police report
My passport	Mi pasaporte	mee pah-sah-POHR-teh	Common lost item
My wallet	Mi cartera / billetera	mee kahr-TEH-rah / bee-yeh-TEH-rah	cartera = Spain, billetera = LatAm
My phone	Mi teléfono / celular	mee teh-LEH-foh-noh / seh-loo-LAHR	teléfono = Spain, celular = LatAm

2.6 Daily Interactions

2.6.1 Convenience Store / Shop

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
This one please	Este/Esta por favor	EHS-teh/EHS-tah por fah-BOR	este = masc, esta = fem
Do you have a bag?	¿Tiene bolsa?	TYEH-neh BOHL-sah	Asking for bag
No bag needed	No necesito bolsa	noh neh-seh-SEE-toh BOHL-sah	Declining bag
How much is this?	¿Cuánto cuesta esto?	KWAHN-toh KWEHS-tah EHS-toh	Asking price
I'll take this	Me llevo esto	meh YEH-boh EHS-toh	Deciding to buy
Receipt please	El recibo por favor	ehl reh-SEE-boh por fah-BOR	Request receipt
Just looking	Solo estoy mirando	SOH-loh ehs-TOY mee-RAHN-doh	Browsing

2.6.2 Payment

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
How much is it?	¿Cuánto es?	KWAHN-toh ehs	Asking total
I'll pay in cash	Pago en efectivo	PAH-goh ehn eh-fehk-TEE-boh	Cash payment
I'll pay by card	Pago con tarjeta	PAH-goh kon tahr-HEH-tah	Card payment
Do you accept credit cards?	¿Aceptan tarjetas de crédito?	ah-SEHP-tahn tahr-HEH-tahs deh KREH-dee-toh	Card acceptance
Can I pay by phone?	¿Puedo pagar con el móvil/celular?	PWEH-doh pah-GAHR kon ehl MOH-beel/seh-loo-LAHR	Mobile payment
Keep the change	Quédese con el cambio	KEH-deh-seh kon ehl KAHM-byoh	Tipping
Can I have change?	¿Tiene cambio?	TYEH-neh KAHM-byoh	Breaking a large bill

2.6.3 Time and Schedules

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
What time is it?	¿Qué hora es?	keh OH-rah ehs	Asking time
What time does it open?	¿A qué hora abre?	ah keh OH-rah AH-breh	Opening time
What time does it close?	¿A qué hora cierra?	ah keh OH-rah SYEH-rrah	Closing time
How long does it take?	¿Cuánto tiempo tarda?	KWAHN-toh TYEHM-poh TAHR-dah	Duration
Is it open today?	¿Está abierto hoy?	ehs-TAH ah-BYEHR-toh oy	Open today?
What are the hours?	¿Cuál es el horario?	kwahl ehs ehl oh-RAH-ryoh	Business hours

2.7 Quick Reference: Yes, No, and Basic Responses

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Yes	Sí	see	Standard yes
No	No	noh	Standard no

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
OK / It's fine	Está bien / Vale	ehs-TAH byehn / BAH-leh	Vale = Spain only
I understand	Entiendo	ehn-TYEHN-doh	Confirmation
I don't understand	No entiendo	noh ehn-TYEHN-doh	Common response
Please	Por favor	por fah-BOR	Universal
No, thank you	No, gracias	noh GRAH-syahs	Declining politely
Just a moment	Un momento	oon moh-MEHN-toh	Request to wait
That's right	Así es / Correcto	ah-SEE ehs / koh-RREHK-toh	Confirmation
Of course	Claro / Por supuesto	KLAH-roh / por soo-PWEHS-toh	Agreement
I think so	Creo que sí	KREH-oh keh see	Tentative yes
I don't know	No sé	noh seh	Common response
Maybe	Quizás / Tal vez	kee-SAHS / tahl behs	Uncertainty
It doesn't matter	No importa / Da igual	noh eem-POHR-tah / dah ee-GWAHL	Da igual = Spain
Perfect	Perfecto	pehr-FEHK-toh	Positive confirmation

3 Language Foundations: Quick Reference

3.1 Sentence Structure

Spanish follows **Subject-Verb-Object (SVO)** order, similar to English. However, Spanish is more flexible — the subject is often dropped because verb conjugation already indicates who is acting.

3.1.1 Basic Word Order

English	Spanish	Notes
I want water	(Yo) quiero agua	Subject "yo" is optional
She speaks Spanish	(Ella) habla español	Subject "ella" is optional
We have a reservation	(Nosotros) tenemos una reserva	Subject often dropped
The restaurant closes at ten	El restaurante cierra a las diez	Subject needed when it's a noun

3.1.2 Questions

Questions in Spanish are formed by intonation (raising voice at end) or by inverting subject and verb. Written questions use inverted question marks: ¿...?

English	Spanish	Notes
Do you have a table?	¿Tiene una mesa?	Verb-first
Where is the exit?	¿Dónde está la salida?	Question word first
How much does it cost?	¿Cuánto cuesta?	Question word first

3.1.3 Question Words

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
What?	¿Qué?	keh
Who?	¿Quién?	kyehn
Where?	¿Dónde?	DOHN-deh
When?	¿Cuándo?	KWAHN-doh
Why?	¿Por qué?	por keh
How?	¿Cómo?	KOH-moh
How much?	¿Cuánto?	KWAHN-toh
How many?	¿Cuántos/Cuántas?	KWAHN-tohs/KWAHN-tahs
Which?	¿Cuál? / ¿Qué?	kwahl / keh

3.2 Gendered Nouns

All Spanish nouns are either **masculine** or **feminine**. This affects articles (el/la) and adjectives.

3.2.1 General Rules

Rule	Masculine	Feminine	Exceptions
Ends in -o	el libro (book)	—	la mano (hand), la foto (photo)
Ends in -a	—	la mesa (table)	el día (day), el mapa (map)
Ends in -ción/-sión	—	la estación (station)	—
Ends in -dad/-tad	—	la ciudad (city)	—
Ends in consonant	Varies	Varies	Check case by case

3.2.2 Articles

	Singular	Plural
Masculine	el (the), un (a)	los (the), unos (some)
Feminine	la (the), una (a)	las (the), unas (some)

3.2.3 Common Examples for Travelers

English	Spanish	Gender	Notes
the hotel	el hotel	masc	
the room	la habitación	fem	
the restaurant	el restaurante	masc	
the table	la mesa	fem	
the bill	la cuenta	fem	
the bathroom	el baño	masc	
the station	la estación	fem	
the airport	el aeropuerto	masc	
the beach	la playa	fem	
the museum	el museo	masc	

3.3 Ser vs. Estar (Both Mean “To Be”)

This is a key distinction in Spanish. Both mean “to be” but are used in different contexts.

3.3.1 When to Use Each

Use Ser for	Use Estar for
Identity: Soy americano (I'm American)	Location: Estoy en Madrid (I'm in Madrid)
Origin: Es de México (He's from Mexico)	Temporary states: Estoy cansado (I'm tired)
Profession: Soy profesor (I'm a teacher)	Emotions: Estoy contento (I'm happy)
Time: Son las tres (It's 3 o'clock)	Conditions: Está cerrado (It's closed)
Characteristics: Es grande (It's big)	Health: Estoy enfermo (I'm sick)
Materials: Es de madera (It's made of wood)	Actions in progress: Estoy comiendo (I'm eating)

3.3.2 Conjugation for Travelers

Pronoun	Ser	Estar
yo (I)	soy	estoy
tú (you, informal)	eres	estás
usted (you, formal)	es	está
él/ella (he/she)	es	está
nosotros (we)	somos	estamos
ustedes (you all)	son	están
ellos/ellas (they)	son	están

3.4 Essential Verb Conjugation

Spanish verbs end in **-ar**, **-er**, or **-ir**. Here are the present tense patterns with the most useful verbs for travelers.

3.4.1 Most Useful Verbs

Infinitive	Meaning	Yo	Tú	Usted/Él/Ella	Nosotros	Ustedes/Ellos
hablar	to speak	hablo	hablas	habla	hablamos	hablan
necesitar	to need	necesito	necesitas	necesita	necesitamos	necesitan
querer	to want	quiero	quieres	quiere	queremos	quieren
poder	to be able	puedo	puedes	puede	podemos	pueden
tener	to have	tengo	tienes	tiene	tenemos	tienen
ir	to go	voy	vas	va	vamos	van
saber	to know (facts)	sé	sabes	sabe	sabemos	saben
conocer	to know (people/- places)	conozco	conoces	conoce	conocemos	conocen
hacer	to do/make	hago	haces	hace	hacemos	hacen
decir	to say/tell	digo	dices	dice	decimos	dicen
pagar	to pay	pago	pagas	paga	pagamos	pagan
comer	to eat	como	comes	come	comemos	comen

3.4.2 Hay — “There is / There are”

One of the most useful words: **hay** (eye) means both “there is” and “there are.”

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
Is there a bathroom?	¿Hay un baño?	eye oon BAH-nyoh
There is no Wi-Fi	No hay Wi-Fi	noh eye
Are there seats available?	¿Hay asientos disponibles?	eye ah-SYEHN-tohs dees-poh-NEE-blehs

3.5 Pronouns

3.5.1 Subject Pronouns

English	Spanish	Notes
I	yo	Often dropped
you (informal)	tú	Friends, same age, casual
you (formal)	usted (Ud.)	Strangers, older people, service
he	él	
she	ella	
we	nosotros/nosotras	-os = masc/mixed, -as = all female
you all (informal, Spain)	vosotros/vosotras	Spain only
you all (formal/LatAm)	ustedes (Uds.)	Universal plural “you”
they	ellos/ellas	

3.5.2 Tú vs. Usted vs. Vos

Pronoun	When to Use	Region
tú	Friends, family, children, peers, casual	Universal
usted	Strangers, elderly, service staff, formal settings	Universal
vos	Same as tú (replaces tú entirely)	Argentina, Uruguay, parts of Central America
vosotros	Plural informal “you all”	Spain only
ustedes	Plural “you all” (formal and informal)	Latin America (all contexts), Spain (formal)

3.6 Numbers

3.6.1 0-20

Number	Spanish	Pronunciation
0	cero	SEH-roh
1	uno	OO-noh
2	dos	dohs
3	tres	trehs
4	cuatro	KWAH-troh
5	cinco	SEEN-koh
6	seis	says
7	siete	SYEH-teh

Number	Spanish	Pronunciation
8	ocho	OH-choh
9	nueve	NWEH-beh
10	diez	dyehs
11	once	OHN-seh
12	doce	DOH-seh
13	trece	TREH-seh
14	catorce	kah-TOHR-seh
15	quince	KEEN-seh
16	dieciséis	dyeh-see-SAYS
17	diecisiete	dyeh-see-SYEH-teh
18	dieciocho	dyeh-see-OH-choh
19	diecinueve	dyeh-see-NWEH-beh
20	veinte	BAYN-teh

3.6.2 Tens, Hundreds, and Beyond

Number	Spanish	Pronunciation
30	treinta	TRAYN-tah
40	cuarenta	kwah-REHN-tah
50	cincuenta	seen-KWEHN-tah
60	sesenta	seh-SEHN-tah
70	setenta	seh-TEHN-tah
80	ochenta	oh-CHEHN-tah
90	noventa	noh-BEHN-tah
100	cien	syehn
200	doscientos	dohs-SYEHN-tohs
500	quinientos	kee-NYEHN-tohs
1,000	mil	meel
1,000,000	un millón	oon mee-YOHN

Combining: 21 = veintiuno, 32 = treinta y dos, 145 = ciento cuarenta y cinco

3.7 Days and Months

3.7.1 Days of the Week

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
Monday	lunes	LOO-nehs
Tuesday	martes	MAHR-tehs
Wednesday	miércoles	MYEHR-koh-lehs
Thursday	jueves	HWEH-behs
Friday	viernes	BYEHR-nehs
Saturday	sábado	SAH-bah-doh
Sunday	domingo	doh-MEEN-goh

Note: Days are not capitalized in Spanish. The week starts on Monday.

3.7.2 Months

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
January	enero	eh-NEH-roh
February	febrero	feh-BREH-roh
March	marzo	MAHR-soh
April	abril	ah-BREEL
May	mayo	MAH-yoh
June	junio	HOO-nyoh
July	julio	HOO-lyoh
August	agosto	ah-GOHS-toh
September	septiembre	sehp-TYEHM-breh
October	octubre	ohk-TOO-breh
November	noviembre	noh-BYEHM-breh
December	diciembre	dee-SYEHM-breh

Note: Months are not capitalized in Spanish.

3.7.3 Useful Time Expressions

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
today	hoy	oy
tomorrow	mañana	mah-NYAH-nah
yesterday	ayer	ah-YEHR
this week	esta semana	EHS-tah seh-MAH-nah
next week	la próxima semana	lah PROHK-see-mah seh-MAH-nah
now	ahora	ah-OH-rah
later	después / luego	dehs-PWEHS / LWEH-goh
in the morning	por la mañana	por lah mah-NYAH-nah
in the afternoon	por la tarde	por lah TAHR-deh
at night	por la noche	por lah NOH-cheh

4 Pronunciation Guide

4.1 Introduction

Spanish pronunciation is highly regular and phonetic — words are pronounced almost exactly as they're written. Once you learn the basic rules, you can pronounce virtually any Spanish word correctly. This makes Spanish one of the most accessible languages for English speakers to learn to pronounce.

Key principle: Spanish is a syllable-timed language (like Japanese), meaning each syllable gets roughly equal time. English is stress-timed, so English speakers need to resist the urge to rush through unstressed syllables.

4.2 Vowels

Spanish has only **5 pure vowel sounds**, and they are **always pronounced the same way**, regardless of context. This consistency is one of the best features of Spanish pronunciation.

4.2.1 The Five Vowels

Vowel	Sound	English Approximation	Example	Meaning
a	"ah"	father	agua (AH-gwah)	water
e	"eh"	bed	esto (EHS-toh)	this
i	"ee"	machine	isla (EES-lah)	island
o	"oh"	go (short, no glide)	ocho (OH-choh)	eight
u	"oo"	food	uno (OO-noh)	one

4.2.2 Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake	Wrong	Right	Example
Making "a" sound like "cat"	/æ/	/ah/	gracias = GRAH-syahs, not GRASS-ee-us
Gliding the "o" like English "go"	/oo/	/o/	no = noh (short, clean)
Reducing unstressed vowels	/uh/	Keep pure	momento = moh-MEHN-toh, not muh-MEN-toh
Making "e" sound like "ee"	/i:/	/eh/	café = kah-FEH, not kah-FEE

4.3 Consonants

Most Spanish consonants sound similar to English, with some important differences.

4.3.1 Consonants That Sound Like English

Letter	Sound	Example	Notes
ch	"ch" in "church"	mucho (MOO-choh)	Same as English
f	"f" in "fun"	fiesta (FYEHS-tah)	Same as English
k	"k" in "kite"	kilo (KEE-loh)	Same as English
l	"l" in "like"	lugar (loo-GAHR)	Same as English
m	"m" in "map"	mesa (MEH-sah)	Same as English
n	"n" in "no"	nada (NAH-dah)	Same as English
p	"p" in "spot"	por (por)	Less aspirated than English
s	"s" in "sun"	sí (see)	Always unvoiced (like "ss")
t	"t" in "stop"	todo (TOH-doh)	Tongue touches teeth, no puff of air

4.3.2 Consonants That Differ from English

Letter	Sound	Example	Key Difference
b/v	Both = "b"	bueno, vino	Identical sound; soft between vowels
c (before e/i)	"s" (LatAm) or "th" (Spain)	cine	See seseo vs. distinción below

Letter	Sound	Example	Key Difference
c (before a/o/u)	"k"	c asa (KAH-sah)	Like English "k"
d	Soft "th" between vowels	na d a (NAH-thah)	Like "th" in "the" between vowels
g (before e/i)	"h" (throaty)	g ente (HEHN-teh)	Like English "h" but stronger
g (before a/o/u)	"g" in "go"	g ato (GAH-toh)	Same as English
h	Silent	h ola (OH-lah)	Never pronounced
j	"h" (throaty)	j ugo (HOO-goh)	Stronger than English "h"
ll	"y" (varies by region)	ll amar (yah-MAHR)	See regional section below
ñ	"ny" in "canyon"	espa ñ ol (ehs-pah-NYOHL)	Unique to Spanish
qu	"k"	qu e (keh)	u is always silent after q
r	Tapped "r"	pe r o (PEH-roh)	Like quick "d" in American "butter"
rr	Trilled "r"	pe rr o (PEH-rroh)	Multiple tongue taps
x	"ks" or "s"	ta x i (TAHK-see)	In Mexico: "sh" or "h" in some words
z	"s" (LatAm) or "th" (Spain)	ce z era	See seseo vs. distinción below

4.4 Special Sounds

4.4.1 Ñ — The Unique Spanish Letter

The **ñ** represents the "ny" sound (like "canyon" or "onion"). It is considered a separate letter in the Spanish alphabet.

Example	Pronunciation	Meaning
español	ehs-pah-NYOHL	Spanish
mañana	mah-NYAH-nah	tomorrow/morning
señor	seh-NYOHR	Mr./sir
año	AH-nyoh	year
niño/niña	NEE-nyoh/NEE-nyah	boy/girl
baño	BAH-nyoh	bathroom

4.4.2 RR — The Rolled R

The double **rr** is trilled (tongue vibrates against roof of mouth). Single **r** at the start of a word is also trilled.

Spelling	Sound	Example	Meaning
rr (between vowels)	Trilled	pe rr o (PEH-rroh)	dog
r (start of word)	Trilled	rojo (RROH-hoh)	red
r (after n, l, s)	Trilled	al r ededor	around
r (other positions)	Tapped	pe r o (PEH-roh)	but

Tip: If you can't roll your R's, a strong single tap is perfectly understandable.

4.4.3 LL — Regional Variation

The pronunciation of **ll** varies significantly by region.

Region	Sound	Example: “llamar”
Most of Spain	“ly” (like “million”)	lyah-MAHR
Most of Latin America	“y” (like “yes”)	yah-MAHR
Argentina/Uruguay	“sh” or “zh”	shah-MAHR
Some rural areas	“j” (like English “jelly”)	jah-MAHR

4.4.4 Silent H

The letter **h** is always silent in Spanish.

Word	Pronunciation	Meaning
hola	OH-lah	hello
hotel	oh-TEHL	hotel
hospital	ohs-pee-TAHL	hospital
hora	OH-rah	hour
hay	eye	there is/are

4.5 Stress Rules

Spanish has very predictable stress rules, and accent marks (´) tell you when the rules are broken.

4.5.1 Default Stress Rules

Rule	Pattern	Example
Words ending in vowel, n , or s	Stress second-to-last syllable	ha- bla -mos, re- pi -ten
Words ending in any other consonant	Stress last syllable	ha- blar , ciu- dad , co- mer
Written accent mark (´)	Stress the marked syllable	ca- fé , te- lé -fo-no, es-ta- ción

4.5.2 Accent Marks Also Distinguish Meaning

Without Accent	Meaning	With Accent	Meaning
si	if	sí	yes
el	the	él	he
tu	your	tú	you
como	like/as	cómo	how?
que	that	qué	what?
donde	where (relative)	dónde	where?

4.6 Seseo vs. Distinción

This is the most notable pronunciation difference between Spain and Latin America.

4.6.1 The Difference

Feature	Spain (most regions)	Latin America
c before e/i	“th” (like “think”)	“s”
z	“th” (like “think”)	“s”
s	“s”	“s”
Term	Distinción	Seseo

4.6.2 Examples

Word	Spain (Distinción)	Latin America (Seseo)
gracias	GRAH-thyahs	GRAH-syahs
cerveza	thehr-BEH-thah	sehr-BEH-sah
zapato	thah-PAH-toh	sah-PAH-toh
cinco	THEEN-koh	SEEN-koh
plaza	PLAH-thah	PLAH-sah

Note: Both are completely correct. Use whichever feels more natural. Southern Spain (Andalusia) and the Canary Islands also use seseo.

4.7 Regional Accent Overview

Region	Key Features
Central Spain (Madrid)	Distinción (c/z = “th”), clear consonants, standard reference
Southern Spain (Andalusia)	Seseo, dropped final -s, relaxed consonants
Mexico	Clear pronunciation, moderate pace, “x” sometimes = “sh” or “h”
Colombia (Bogotá)	Considered very clear and “neutral,” popular for language learning
Argentina (Buenos Aires)	ll/y = “sh,” Italian-influenced intonation, vos instead of tú
Caribbean (Cuba, PR, DR)	Fast pace, dropped final consonants, aspirated -s
Chile	Fast speech, heavy slang, dropped -s, unique vocabulary

4.8 Pronunciation Tips for Common Tourist Phrases

Phrase	Careful Pronunciation	Common Mistakes
Gracias	GRAH-syahs	Don’t say “GRASS-ee-us”
Buenos días	BWEH-nohs DEE-ahs	Don’t say “BWEN-ohs”
Por favor	por fah-BOR	Don’t say “por FAY-vor”
¿Dónde está?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH	Don’t say “DON-day ES-tah”
La cuenta	lah KWEHN-tah	Don’t say “lah KWEN-tah”
Baño	BAH-nyoh	Don’t forget the “ny” sound
Calle	KAH-yeh	Not “KAL-ee”
Cerveza	sehr-BEH-sah	Don’t say “ser-VEZ-ah”

5 Writing System & Special Characters

5.1 The Spanish Alphabet

Spanish uses the Latin alphabet with **27 letters** — the standard 26 plus **ñ**. The letters **ch** and **ll** were historically separate letters but are no longer treated as such in modern alphabetical ordering.

5.1.1 Full Alphabet

Letter	Name	Pronunciation of Name
A	a	ah
B	be	beh
C	ce	seh (LatAm) / theh (Spain)
D	de	deh
E	e	eh
F	efe	EH-feh
G	ge	heh
H	hache	AH-cheh
I	i	ee
J	jota	HOH-tah
K	ka	kah
L	ele	EH-leh
M	eme	EH-meh
N	ene	EH-neh
Ñ	eñe	EH-nyeh
O	o	oh
P	pe	peh
Q	cu	koo
R	erre	EH-rreh
S	ese	EH-seh
T	te	teh
U	u	oo
V	uve	OO-beh
W	uve doble	OO-beh DOH-bleh
X	equis	EH-kees
Y	ye / i griega	yeh / ee GRYEH-gah
Z	zeta	SEH-tah (LatAm) / THEH-tah (Spain)

5.1.2 Letters Rarely Used

K and **W** appear almost exclusively in borrowed words (kilo, whisky, wifi).

5.2 Accent Marks (Tildes)

Spanish uses only one type of accent mark: the **acute accent** (´), which goes over vowels: **á, é, í, ó, ú**.

5.2.1 What Accent Marks Do

Function	Example	Explanation
Indicate stress	café, teléfono, estación	Stress falls on the marked syllable
Distinguish homophones	sí (yes) vs. si (if)	Different words, same spelling otherwise
Mark question words	¿qué? ¿dónde? ¿cuándo?	Always accented in questions/exclamations

5.2.2 Words Travelers Will See with Accents

Word	Pronunciation	Meaning
café	kah-FEH	coffee / café
estación	ehs-tah-SYOHN	station
dirección	dee-rehk-SYOHN	direction / address
información	een-for-mah-SYOHN	information
teléfono	teh-LEH-foh-noh	telephone
menú	meh-NOO	menu
autobús	ow-toh-BOOS	bus
número	NOO-meh-roh	number
habitación	ah-bee-tah-SYOHN	room
farmacia	fahr-MAH-syah	pharmacy (no accent — regular stress)

5.3 The Dieresis (ü)

The **ü** (u with dieresis) appears only in the combinations **güe** and **güi**, where it indicates the **u** must be pronounced (normally u is silent after g before e/i).

With ü (u pronounced)	Without ü (u silent)
biling güe (bee-LEEN-gweh) = bilingual	guerra (GEH-rrah) = war
verg üenza (behr-GWEHN-sah) = shame	guitar (gee-TAHR) = to guide
ping üino (peen-GWEE-noh) = penguin	guia (GEE-ah) = guide

5.4 Inverted Punctuation: ¿ and ¡

Spanish is unique in using **inverted question and exclamation marks** at the **beginning** of questions and exclamations. This helps readers know the sentence's tone from the start.

5.4.1 Examples

Type	Spanish	Notes
Question	¿Dónde está el hotel?	¿ at start, ? at end
Exclamation	¡Qué bonito!	¡ at start, ! at end
Mixed	¿Cuánto cuesta? ¡Es muy caro!	Each sentence gets its own marks
Mid-sentence	Señor, ¿puede ayudarme?	¿ starts where the question begins

Note: In casual texting and social media, many Spanish speakers drop the inverted marks. In formal writing, they're always required.

5.5 Typing Special Characters

5.5.1 On a Phone

Most phone keyboards offer Spanish characters by **long-pressing** the base letter: - Long-press **a** → á, Long-press **n** → ñ - Add a Spanish keyboard in your phone settings for the easiest experience

5.5.2 On a Computer

Character	Windows (US keyboard)	Mac (US keyboard)	Alternative
á	Alt + 0225	Option + e, then a	
é	Alt + 0233	Option + e, then e	
í	Alt + 0237	Option + e, then i	
ó	Alt + 0243	Option + e, then o	
ú	Alt + 0250	Option + e, then u	
ñ	Alt + 0241	Option + n, then n	
ü	Alt + 0252	Option + u, then u	
¿	Alt + 0191	Option + Shift + ?	
¡	Alt + 0161	Option + 1	

Tip: Adding an international or Spanish keyboard layout is the easiest long-term solution.

5.6 Reading Signs and Public Text

5.6.1 Common Signs You'll See

Spanish	English	Where You'll See It
SALIDA	Exit	Airports, metro, buildings
ENTRADA	Entrance	Buildings, parking
ABIERTO / CERRADO	Open / Closed	Shops, restaurants
EMPUJAR / TIRAR	Push / Pull	Doors
PROHIBIDO	Prohibited/Forbidden	Various restrictions
NO FUMAR	No Smoking	Public spaces
CUIDADO	Caution	Warning signs
PELIGRO	Danger	Hazard areas
SERVICIOS / ASEOS / BAÑOS	Restrooms	Servicios/Aseos = Spain, Baños = LatAm
CABALLEROS / DAMAS	Men / Women	Restrooms
HOMBRES / MUJERES	Men / Women	Restrooms
LIBRE / OCUPADO	Free / Occupied	Restroom locks, taxis
CAJA	Checkout / Cash register	Stores
REBAJAS / OFERTA	Sales / Offer	Shops
NO PASAR	Do Not Enter	Restricted areas
OBRAS	Construction	Road/building work

5.6.2 Transport Signs

Spanish	English	Context
LLEGADAS	Arrivals	Airport
SALIDAS	Departures	Airport
ANDÉN	Platform	Train station
VÍA	Track	Train station
PARADA	Stop	Bus stop
DIRECCIÓN	Direction	Metro line direction
CORRESPONDENCIA	Transfer	Metro connection
BILLETE / BOLETO	Ticket	billete = Spain, boleto = LatAm

5.7 Number Formatting

Spanish-speaking countries format numbers differently from English.

5.7.1 Decimal and Thousands Separators

Convention	Example	Where Used
Period for thousands, comma for decimal	1.500,50	Spain, Argentina, and most of LatAm
Comma for thousands, period for decimal	1,500.50	Mexico, Puerto Rico

5.7.2 Currency Display

Country	Currency	Format Example
Spain	Euro (€)	15,50 €
Mexico	Peso (MXN, \$)	\$1,500.00
Argentina	Peso (ARS, \$)	\$1.500,00
Colombia	Peso (COP, \$)	\$50.000

5.7.3 Date Format

Spanish-speaking countries use **day/month/year** (not month/day/year): - **15/03/2026** = March 15, 2026 - **Written:** 15 de marzo de 2026

5.7.4 Time Format

Format	Example	Usage
24-hour	14:30	Official schedules, Spain
12-hour	2:30 p.m.	Casual speech, some LatAm countries

5.7.5 Telling Time

English	Spanish
It's 1:00	Es la una
It's 2:00	Son las dos
It's 3:30	Son las tres y media

English	Spanish
It's 4:15	Son las cuatro y cuarto
It's 4:45	Son las cinco menos cuarto
At 8 in the morning	A las ocho de la mañana
At 9 at night	A las nueve de la noche

6 Directions, Walking, and Navigation

6.1 Core Direction Words

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
straight	recto / derecho	RREHK-toh / deh-REH-choh	Both used; todo recto = go straight
right	derecha	deh-REH-chah	a la derecha = to the right
left	izquierda	ees-KYEHR-dah	a la izquierda = to the left
here	aquí	ah-KEE	
there	ahí / allí	ah-EE / ah-YEE	ahí = near you, allí = farther
over there	allá	ah-YAH	More distant
near	cerca	SEHR-kah	cerca de = near to
far	lejos	LEH-hohs	lejos de = far from
inside	dentro	DEHN-troh	dentro de = inside of
outside	fuera	FWEH-rah	fuera de = outside of
in front of	delante de / enfrente de	deh-LAHN-teh deh / ehn-FREHN-teh deh	
behind	detrás de	deh-TRAHS deh	
next to	al lado de	ahl LAH-doh deh	
across from	enfrente de	ehn-FREHN-teh deh	
between	entre	EHN-treh	
corner	esquina	ehs-KEE-nah	la esquina de la calle
intersection	cruce / intersección	KROO-seh	
traffic light	semáforo	seh-MAH-foh-roh	
block (city)	cuadra (LatAm) / manzana (Spain)	KWAH-drah / mahn-SAH-nah	
bridge	puente	PWEHN-teh	
floor/story	piso / planta	PEE-soh / PLAHN-tah	piso = LatAm, planta = Spain
entrance	entrada	ehn-TRAH-dah	
exit	salida	sah-LEE-dah	
stairs	escaleras	ehs-kah-LEH-rahs	

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
elevator	ascensor (Spain) / elevador (LatAm)	ah-sehn-SOHR / eh-leh-bah-DOHR	

6.2 Asking for Directions

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Where is ___?	¿Dónde está ___?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH	Swap in place
How do I get to ___?	¿Cómo llego a ___?	KOH-moh YEH-goh ah	
Is it far?	¿Está lejos?	ehs-TAH LEH-hohs	
Is it close?	¿Está cerca?	ehs-TAH SEHR-kah	
Can I walk there?	¿Se puede ir caminando?	seh PWEH-deh eer kah-mee-NAHN-doh	
How far is it on foot?	¿A cuántos minutos a pie?	ah KWAHN-tohs mee-NOO-tohs ah pyeh	
Which way?	¿Por dónde?	por DOHN-deh	
Which exit?	¿Cuál salida?	kwahl sah-LEE-dah	At stations
Show me on the map, please	Muéstreme en el mapa, por favor	MWEHS-treh-meh ehn ehl MAH-pah	Very useful
Can you write it down?	¿Puede escribirlo?	PWEH-deh ehs-kree-BEER-loh	Helpful for addresses
I'm looking for this address	Busco esta dirección	BOOS-koh EHS-tah dee-rehk-SYOHN	Show written address

6.3 Understanding Directions You'll Hear

Spanish	English	Pronunciation
Siga todo recto	Go straight	SEE-gah TOH-doh RREHK-toh
Gire a la derecha	Turn right	HEE-reh ah lah deh-REH-chah
Gire a la izquierda	Turn left	HEE-reh ah lah ees-KYEHR-dah
En la esquina	At the corner	ehn lah ehs-KEE-nah
En el semáforo	At the traffic light	ehn ehl seh-MAH-foh-roh
La primera calle	The first street	lah pree-MEH-rah KAH-yeh
La segunda calle	The second street	lah seh-GOON-dah KAH-yeh
Al final de la calle	At the end of the street	ahl fee-NAHL deh lah KAH-yeh
Está a dos cuadras	It's two blocks away	ehs-TAH ah dohs KWAH-drahs
Cruce la calle	Cross the street	KROO-seh lah KAH-yeh
Está al lado de	It's next to	ehs-TAH ahl LAH-doh deh
No tiene pierde	You can't miss it	noh TYEH-neh PYEHR-deh

6.4 Sample Direction Conversations

Asking for the metro: - Usted: Disculpe, ¿dónde está la estación de metro más cercana? (*Excuse me, where is the nearest metro station?*) - Respuesta: Siga todo recto dos cuadras, gire a la derecha, y está al final de la calle. (*Go straight two blocks, turn right, and it's at the end of the street.*)

Finding a restaurant: - Usted: ¿Cómo llego al restaurante El Patio? (*How do I get to El Patio restaurant?*) - Respuesta: Está muy cerca. Cruce la plaza y es la segunda calle a la izquierda. (*It's very close. Cross the plaza and it's the second street on the left.*)

6.5 Common Landmarks for Navigation

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
plaza / square	la plaza	lah PLAH-sah
church	la iglesia	lah ee-GLEH-syah
cathedral	la catedral	lah kah-teh-DRAHL
park	el parque	ehl PAHR-keh
fountain	la fuente	lah FWEHN-teh
museum	el museo	ehl moo-SEH-oh
market	el mercado	ehl mehr-KAH-doh
pharmacy	la farmacia	lah fahr-MAH-syah
bank	el banco	ehl BAHN-koh
supermarket	el supermercado	ehl soo-pehr-mehr-KAH-doh
post office	la oficina de correos	lah oh-fee-SEE-nah deh koh-RREH-ohs
hospital	el hospital	ehl ohs-pee-TAHL
police station	la comisaría	lah koh-mee-sah-REE-ah
beach	la playa	lah PLAH-yah
river	el río	ehl RREE-oh
hill/mountain	la colina / la montaña	lah koh-LEE-nah / lah mohn-TAH-nyah

6.6 Using Maps and Apps

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
map	mapa	MAH-pah
Do you have a map?	¿Tiene un mapa?	TYEH-neh oon MAH-pah
Where am I on this map?	¿Dónde estoy en este mapa?	DOHN-deh ehs-TOY ehn EHS-teh
I'm using GPS	Estoy usando el GPS	MAH-pah ehs-TOY oo-SAHN-doh ehl heh-peh-EH-seh
The address is...	La dirección es...	lah dee-rehk-SYOHN ehs
What is this street called?	¿Cómo se llama esta calle?	KOH-moh seh YAH-mah EHS-tah KAH-yeh
street	calle	KAH-yeh
avenue	avenida	ah-beh-NEE-dah
road/highway	carretera	kah-rreh-TEH-rah
neighborhood	barrio (Spain) / colonia (Mexico)	BAH-rryoh / koh-LOH-nyah

6.7 Ordinal Numbers for Directions

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
first	primero/a	pree-MEH-roh
second	segundo/a	seh-GOON-doh
third	tercero/a	tehr-SEH-roh
fourth	cuarto/a	KWAHR-toh
fifth	quinto/a	KEEN-toh

7 Transportation

7.1 Overview by Region

Transport	Spain	Mexico	Argentina
High-speed train	AVE (Renfe)	—	—
Commuter rail	Cercanías	Tren Suburbano	Tren (lines Mitre, Sarmiento, etc.)
Metro/Subway	Metro (Madrid, Barcelona)	Metro (CDMX)	Subte (Buenos Aires)
City bus	Autobús / Bus	Camión / Autobús	Colectivo
Long-distance bus	Autobús	Autobús / Camión	Micro / Ómnibus
Taxi	Taxi	Taxi / Uber	Taxi / Uber / Remis
Transit card	Tarjeta Multi (Madrid)	Tarjeta MI (CDMX)	Tarjeta SUBE
Ride-hailing	Uber, Cabify	Uber, Didi	Uber, Cabify

7.2 Buying Tickets

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Where can I buy a ticket?	¿Dónde puedo comprar un billete/boleto?	DOHN-deh PWEH-doh kohm-PRAHR oon bee-YEH-teh/boh-LEH-toh	billete = Spain, boleto = LatAm
A ticket to [place]	Un billete/boleto a [lugar]	oon bee-YEH-teh/boh-LEH-toh ah [loo-GAHR]	
One-way	Solo ida	SOH-loh EE-dah	
Round-trip	Ida y vuelta	EE-dah ee BWEHL-tah	
How much is a ticket to ___?	¿Cuánto cuesta un billete a ___?	KWAHN-toh KWEHS-tah oon bee-YEH-teh ah	
First class	Primera clase	pree-MEH-rah KLAH-seh	
Second class	Segunda clase	seh-GOON-dah KLAH-seh	
Student discount	Descuento de estudiante	dehs-KWEHN-toh deh ehs-too-DYAHN-teh	
Is there a day pass?	¿Hay un abono de día?	eye oon ah-BOH-noh deh DEE-ah	
I need to top up my card	Necesito recargar mi tarjeta	neh-seh-SEE-toh rreh-kahr-GAHR mee tahr-HEH-tah	
Where is the ticket machine?	¿Dónde está la máquina de billetes?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH lah MAH-kee-nah	

7.3 Metro / Subway

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Where is the metro station?	¿Dónde está la estación de metro?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH lah ehs-tah-SYOHN deh MEH-troh	
Which line goes to ___?	¿Qué línea va a ___?	keh LEE-neh-ah bah ah	

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Do I need to transfer?	¿Tengo que hacer transbordo?	TEHN-goh keh ah-SEHR trahns-BOHR-doh	
Where do I transfer?	¿Dónde hago el transbordo?	DOHN-deh AH-goh ehl trahns-BOHR-doh	
Which direction?	¿En qué dirección?	ehn keh dee-rehk-SYOHN	
Next stop	Próxima parada	PROHK-see-mah pah-RAH-dah	
Last train	Último tren/metro	OOL-tee-moh trehn/MEH-troh	
The doors are closing	Se cierran las puertas	seh SYEH-rrahn lahs PWEHR-tahs	Announcement
Careful with the gap	Cuidado con el hueco	kwee-DAH-doh kon ehl WEH-koh	Spain: "Mind the gap"
platform	andén	ahn-DEHN	
transfer/connection	correspondencia / transbordo	koh-rrehs-pohn-DEHN-syah	

7.4 Trains (Long Distance)

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
train station	la estación de tren	lah ehs-tah-SYOHN deh trehn	
When is the next train to ___?	¿Cuándo sale el próximo tren a ___?	KWAHN-doh SAH-leh ehl PROHK-see-moh trehn ah	
What platform?	¿Qué andén? / ¿Qué vía?	keh ahn-DEHN / keh BEE-ah	
Is this the train to ___?	¿Es este el tren a ___?	ehs EHS-teh ehl trehn ah	
Is this seat taken?	¿Está ocupado este asiento?	ehs-TAH oh-koo-PAH-doh EHS-teh ah-SYEHN-toh	
Where is my seat?	¿Dónde está mi asiento?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH mee ah-SYEHN-toh	
I have a reservation	Tengo una reserva	TEHN-goh OO-nah rreh-SEHR-bah	
The train is delayed	El tren está retrasado	ehl trehn ehs-TAH rreh-trah-SAH-doh	
arrival	llegada	yeh-GAH-dah	
departure	salida	sah-LEE-dah	
timetable	horario	oh-RAH-ryoh	

7.4.1 Spain Train Types

Train	Description	Notes
AVE	High-speed (up to 310 km/h)	Madrid-Barcelona, Madrid-Seville
Alvia	Medium-distance fast train	Regional connections
Cercanías	Commuter rail	Urban/suburban travel
Renfe	National rail company	Operates all of the above

7.5 Bus

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
bus stop	la parada de autobús	lah pah-RAH-dah deh ow-toh-BOOS	
bus station	la estación de autobuses / terminal	lah ehs-tah-SYOHN deh ow-toh-BOO-sehs	
Which bus goes to ___?	¿Qué autobús va a ___?	keh ow-toh-BOOS bah ah	
Does this bus go to ___?	¿Este autobús va a ___?	EHS-teh ow-toh-BOOS bah ah	
Where does this bus go?	¿Adónde va este autobús?	ah-DOHN-deh bah EHS-teh ow-toh-BOOS	
Can you tell me when to get off?	¿Me puede avisar cuándo bajarme?	meh PWEH-deh ah-bee-SAHR KWAHN-doh bah-HAHR-meh	Very useful
I want to get off here	Quiero bajarme aquí	KYEH-roh bah-HAHR-meh ah-KEE	
Next stop, please	La próxima parada, por favor	lah PROHK-see-mah pah-RAH-dah	
How often does the bus come?	¿Cada cuánto pasa el autobús?	KAH-dah KWAHN-toh PAH-sah	
Is there a night bus?	¿Hay autobús nocturno?	eye ow-toh-BOOS nohk-TOOR-noh	

7.5.1 Regional Bus Vocabulary

Region	Word for “Bus”	Notes
Spain	autobús, bus	
Mexico	camión, autobús	camión is most common
Argentina	colectivo, bondi (slang)	
Chile	micro	
Colombia	bus, buseta	
Caribbean	guagua	Cuba, Dominican Republic, Puerto Rico

7.6 Taxis and Ride-Hailing

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I need a taxi	Necesito un taxi	neh-seh-SEE-toh oon TAHK-see	
Where is the taxi stand?	¿Dónde está la parada de taxis?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH lah pah-RAH-dah deh TAHK-sees	
Take me to [place], please	Lléveme a [lugar], por favor	YEH-beh-meh ah [loo-GAHR] por fah-BOR	
To this address, please	A esta dirección, por favor	ah EHS-tah dee-rehk-SYOHN por fah-BOR	Show your phone/paper
How much to go to ___?	¿Cuánto cuesta ir a ___?	KWAHN-toh KWEHS-tah eer ah	Agree price first where no meter
Please use the meter	Por favor, use el taxímetro	por fah-BOR OO-seh ehl tahk-SEE-meh-troh	Important in some cities
Stop here, please	Pare aquí, por favor	PAH-reh ah-KEE por fah-BOR	
Can you wait?	¿Puede esperar?	PWEH-deh ehs-peh-RAHR	

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Keep the change	Quédese con el cambio	KEH-deh-seh kon ehl KAHM-byoh	
Can I pay by card?	¿Puedo pagar con tarjeta?	PWEH-doh pah-GAHR kon tahr-HEH-tah	
I'm in a hurry	Tengo prisa	TEHN-goh PREE-sah	
Please drive slowly	Por favor, conduzca despacio	por fah-BOR kohn-DOOS-kah dehs-PAH-syoh	

7.6.1 Taxi Tips by Region

City	Tip
Madrid/Barcelona	Metered taxis, supplements for airport/luggage. Tipping optional (round up).
Mexico City	Use authorized taxis (pink/white) or apps. Avoid hailing random taxis.
Buenos Aires	Metered (reloj). Remis = pre-arranged car service, agreed price.
Bogotá	Use apps (Uber, InDriver). If hailing, confirm they use the meter.

7.7 Airport

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
airport	aeropuerto	ah-eh-roh-PWEHR-toh	
arrivals	llegadas	yeh-GAH-dahs	
departures	salidas	sah-LEE-dahs	
terminal	terminal	tehr-mee-NAHL	
gate	puerta de embarque	PWEHR-tah deh ehm-BAHR-keh	
boarding pass	tarjeta de embarque	tahr-HEH-tah deh ehm-BAHR-keh	
check-in	facturación / check-in	fahk-too-rah-SYOHN	
baggage claim	recogida de equipaje	rreh-koh-HEE-dah deh eh-kee-PAH-heh	
customs	aduanas	ah-DWAH-nah	
passport control	control de pasaportes	kohn-TROHL deh pah-sah-POHR-tehs	
flight	vuelo	BWEH-loh	
boarding	embarque	ehm-BAHR-keh	
My flight is delayed	Mi vuelo está retrasado	mee BWEH-loh ehs-TAH rreh-trah-SAH-doh	
Where is gate ___?	¿Dónde está la puerta ___?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH lah PWEHR-tah	
I've lost my luggage	He perdido mi equipaje	eh pehr-DEE-doh mee eh-kee-PAH-heh	
Where can I get a taxi?	¿Dónde puedo tomar un taxi?	DOHN-deh PWEH-doh toh-MAHR oon TAHK-see	

7.8 Renting a Car

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I want to rent a car	Quiero alquilar/rentar un coche/carro	KYEH-roh ahl-kee-LAHR/rrehn-TAHR oon KOH-cheh/KAH-rroh	alquilar/coche = Spain, rentar/carro = LatAm
driver's license	carnet de conducir / licencia de conducir	kahr-NEHT / lee-SEHN-syah	carnet = Spain, licencia = LatAm
insurance	seguro	seh-GOO-roh	
gas station	gasolinera	gah-soh-lee-NEH-rah	
Fill it up, please	Lleno, por favor	YEH-noh por fah-BOR	
parking	aparcamiento (Spain) / estacionamiento (LatAm)	ah-pahr-kah-MYEHN-toh / ehs-tah-syoh-nah-MYEHN-toh	
highway / toll road	autopista / peaje	ow-toh-PEES-tah / peh-AH-heh	

7.9 Transit Cards

City	Card Name	Where to Buy	How to Top Up
Madrid	Tarjeta Multi	Metro stations, estancos (tobacco shops)	Metro machines, app
Barcelona	T-casual (10 trips)	Metro stations	At machines
Mexico City	Tarjeta MI	Metro stations	Metro station machines
Buenos Aires	SUBE	Kioscos, subway stations	Kioscos, SUBE machines, app
Bogotá	Tarjeta Tu Llave	TransMilenio stations	At stations

7.9.1 Common Transit Phrases

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
Where can I buy a card?	¿Dónde puedo comprar una tarjeta?	DOHN-deh PWEH-doh kohm-PRAHR OO-nah tahr-HEH-tah
I need to top up	Necesito recargar	neh-seh-SEE-toh rreh-kahr-GAHR
Can I use this card on the bus?	¿Puedo usar esta tarjeta en el autobús?	PWEH-doh oo-SAHR EHS-tah tahr-HEH-tah
How much is left on my card?	¿Cuánto me queda en la tarjeta?	KWAHN-toh meh KEH-dah ehn lah tahr-HEH-tah

8 Restaurants and Dining

8.1 Dining Flow: Arrival to Payment

8.1.1 Step 1: Arriving and Getting a Table

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
A table for [number], please	Una mesa para [número], por favor	OO-nah MEH-sah PAH-rah [NOO-meh-roh] por fah-BOR	
Do you have a table?	¿Tiene una mesa?	TYEH-neh OO-nah MEH-sah	
I have a reservation	Tengo una reserva	TEHN-goh OO-nah rreh-SEHR-bah	
A reservation for [name]	Una reserva a nombre de [nombre]	OO-nah rreh-SEHR-bah ah NOHM-breh deh	
Can we sit outside?	¿Podemos sentarnos afuera?	poh-DEH-mohs sehn-TAHR-nohs ah-FWEH-rah	
Can we sit by the window?	¿Podemos sentarnos junto a la ventana?	poh-DEH-mohs sehn-TAHR-nohs HOON-toh ah lah behn-TAH-nah	
Is there a wait?	¿Hay que esperar?	eye keh ehs-peh-RAHR	
How long is the wait?	¿Cuánto hay que esperar?	KWAHN-toh eye keh ehs-peh-RAHR	
Is this table free?	¿Está libre esta mesa?	ehs-TAH LEE-breh EHS-tah MEH-sah	At casual places

8.1.2 Step 2: Ordering

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
The menu, please	La carta/el menú, por favor	lah KAHR-tah / ehl meh-NOO por fah-BOR	carta = more common in Spain
Do you have a menu in English?	¿Tienen carta en inglés?	TYEH-nehn KAHR-tah ehn een-GLEHS	
What do you recommend?	¿Qué recomienda?	keh rreh-koh-MYEHN-dah	
What is the dish of the day?	¿Cuál es el plato del día?	kwahl ehs ehl PLAH-toh dehl DEE-ah	
What is the set menu?	¿Cuál es el menú del día?	kwahl ehs ehl meh-NOO dehl DEE-ah	Common lunch deal in Spain
I'll have [dish]	Voy a pedir [plato] / Para mí, [plato]	boy ah peh-DEER / PAH-rah mee	
For me, the [dish]	Para mí, el/la [plato]	PAH-rah mee ehl/lah	
And for my friend	Y para mi amigo/amiga	ee PAH-rah mee ah-MEE-goh/gah	
Can I see the wine list?	¿Puedo ver la carta de vinos?	PWEH-doh behr lah KAHR-tah deh BEE-nohs	
A glass of red/white wine	Una copa de vino tinto/blanco	OO-nah KOH-pah deh BEE-noh TEEN-toh/BLAHN-koh	
A beer, please	Una cerveza, por favor	OO-nah sehr-BEH-sah por fah-BOR	
Water, please	Agua, por favor	AH-gwah por fah-BOR	
Sparkling or still?	¿Con gas o sin gas?	kon gahs oh seen gahs	You'll be asked this
Still water	Agua sin gas	AH-gwah seen gahs	
Sparkling water	Agua con gas	AH-gwah kon gahs	

8.1.3 Step 3: During the Meal

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
This is delicious	Esto está delicioso/riquísimo	EHS-toh ehs-TAH deh-lee-SYOH-soh/rree-KEE-see-moh	riquísimo is more enthusiastic
Can I have more [thing]?	¿Me puede traer más [cosa]?	meh PWEH-deh trah-EHR mahs	
More bread, please	Más pan, por favor	mahs pahn por fah-BOR	Bread is usually free in Spain
Excuse me (waiter)	Disculpe / ¡Perdone!	dees-KOOL-peh / pehr-DOH-neh	To call the waiter
This isn't what I ordered	Esto no es lo que pedí	EHS-toh noh ehs loh keh peh-DEE	
It's cold	Está frío	ehs-TAH FREE-oh	Sending food back
Can I have a napkin?	¿Me puede dar una servilleta?	meh PWEH-deh dahr OO-nah sehr-bee-YEH-tah	
Where is the bathroom?	¿Dónde está el baño?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH ehl BAH-nyoh	
No more, thank you	No más, gracias	noh mahs GRAH-syahs	

8.1.4 Step 4: Payment

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
The bill, please	La cuenta, por favor	lah KWEHN-tah por fah-BOR	
Can we pay?	¿Podemos pagar?	poh-DEH-mohs pah-GAHR	
Can we pay separately?	¿Podemos pagar por separado?	poh-DEH-mohs pah-GAHR por seh-pah-RAH-doh	
All together	Todo junto	TOH-doh HOON-toh	
I'll pay	Yo pago / Yo invito	yoh PAH-goh / yoh een-BEE-toh	invito = "my treat"
Do you accept cards?	¿Aceptan tarjeta?	ah-SEHP-tahn tahr-HEH-tah	
Is tip included?	¿Está incluida la propina?	ehs-TAH een-kloo-EE-dah lah proh-PEE-nah	
Keep the change	Quédese con el cambio	KEH-deh-seh kon ehl KAHM-byoh	

8.2 Dietary Needs and Allergies

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I'm vegetarian	Soy vegetariano/a	soy beh-heh-tah-RYAH-noh/nah	
I'm vegan	Soy vegano/a	soy beh-GAH-noh/nah	
I don't eat meat	No como carne	noh KOH-moh KAH-neh	
I don't eat pork	No como cerdo	noh KOH-moh SEHR-doh	
I don't eat fish	No como pescado	noh KOH-moh pehs-KAH-doh	
I'm allergic to [food]	Soy alérgico/a a [comida]	soy ah-LEHR-hee-koh/kah ah	

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I'm allergic to nuts	Soy alérgico/a a los frutos secos	soy ah-LEHR-hee-koh ah lohs FROO-tohs SEH-kohs	
I'm allergic to shellfish	Soy alérgico/a a los mariscos	soy ah-LEHR-hee-koh ah lohs mah-REES-kohs	
I'm lactose intolerant	Soy intolerante a la lactosa	soy een-toh-leh-RAHN-teh ah lah lahk-TOH-sah	
Gluten-free	Sin gluten	seen GLOO-tehn	
Does this contain [ingredient]?	¿Esto contiene [ingrediente]?	EHS-toh kohn-TYEH-neh	
Without [ingredient], please	Sin [ingrediente], por favor	seen [een-greh-DYEHN-teh] por fah-BOR	
Is this spicy?	¿Esto es picante?	EHS-toh ehs pee-KAHN-teh	
Not spicy, please	Sin picante, por favor	seen pee-KAHN-teh por fah-BOR	
halal	halal	ah-LAHL	
kosher	kosher	KOH-shehr	

8.3 Regional Food Vocabulary

8.3.1 Meal Names

Meal	Spain	Mexico	Argentina
Breakfast	desayuno	desayuno	desayuno
Late morning snack	almuerzo (light)	almuerzo	—
Lunch	comida (2–4 PM)	comida (2–4 PM)	almuerzo (12–2 PM)
Afternoon snack	merienda (~6 PM)	merienda	merienda
Dinner	cena (9–11 PM)	cena (7–9 PM)	cena (9–10 PM)

8.3.2 Common Food Items

English	Spain	Mexico	Argentina
juice	zumo	jugo	jugo
potato	patata	papa	papa
shrimp	gamba	camarón	camarón/langostino
corn	maíz	elote/maíz	choclo
beans	judías/alubias	frijoles	porotos
cake	tarta	pastel	torta
sandwich	bocadillo	torta/sándwich	sándwich
avocado	aguacate	aguacate	palta
peach	melocotón	durazno	durazno
banana	plátano	plátano	banana
peanut	cacahuete	cacahuete	maní
popcorn	palomitas	palomitas	pochoclo

8.3.3 Types of Cuisine You'll Encounter

Spanish	English	Where
tapas	small shared plates	Spain
pintxos/pinchos	Basque-style tapas (on toothpick)	Northern Spain
menú del día	set lunch menu (starter + main + dessert + drink)	Spain
tacos, enchiladas, tamales	Mexican staples	Mexico
asado	barbecue	Argentina
empanadas	stuffed pastries	Argentina, Chile
arepas	corn cakes	Colombia, Venezuela
ceviche	citrus-marinated seafood	Peru, Ecuador

8.4 Tipping Guide

Country	Tipping Custom
Spain	Not expected. Round up or leave small change. 5-10% for exceptional service.
Mexico	10-15% is standard at sit-down restaurants. Check if “propina incluida.”
Argentina	10% is standard at sit-down restaurants. Cash tips preferred.
Colombia	10% often added automatically (“servicio voluntario”). You can decline.
Chile	10% is standard. Often added to the bill.
Peru	10% at nice restaurants. Not required at casual spots.

8.5 Common Cooking Methods

Spanish	English
a la plancha	grilled (on flat grill)
a la parrilla	grilled (over coals)
al horno	baked/roasted
frito/a	fried
al vapor	steamed
crudo/a	raw
cocido/a	boiled/cooked
guisado/a	stewed
asado/a	roasted/grilled
salteado/a	sautéed
relleno/a	stuffed
ahumado/a	smoked

8.6 Ordering Coffee

Coffee culture is strong across the Spanish-speaking world.

English	Spanish	Notes
Black coffee	Café solo (Spain) / Café negro (LatAm)	Espresso-based in Spain
Coffee with milk	Café con leche	Standard everywhere
Small coffee with a bit of milk	Cortado	Popular in Spain and Argentina
Iced coffee	Café con hielo (Spain) / Café helado (LatAm)	In Spain: served separately on ice
Decaf	Descafeinado	
With sugar	Con azúcar	
Without sugar	Sin azúcar	
To go	Para llevar	
For here	Para tomar aquí	

9 Shopping

9.1 General Shopping Phrases

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I'm just looking	Solo estoy mirando	SOH-loh ehs-TOY mee-RAHN-doh	Browsing
Can you help me?	¿Puede ayudarme?	PWEH-deh ah-yoo-DAHR-meh	
I'm looking for [item]	Estoy buscando [cosa]	ehs-TOY boos-KAHN-doh [KO-sah]	
Do you have [item]?	¿Tiene [cosa]?	TYEH-neh [KO-sah]	lo = masc, la = fem
Do you have this in [color/size]?	¿Lo/La tiene en [color/talla]?	loh/lah TYEH-neh ehn	
Can I see that one?	¿Puedo ver ese/esa?	PWEH-doh behr EH-seh/EH-sah	
How much is this?	¿Cuánto cuesta esto?	KWAHN-toh KWEHS-tah EHS-toh	ese = masc, esa = fem
That's too expensive	Es muy caro	ehs mooy KAH-roh	lo = masc item, la = fem
Do you have anything cheaper?	¿Tiene algo más barato?	TYEH-neh AHL-goh mahs bah-RAH-toh	
I'll take it	Me lo/la llevo	meh loh/lah YEH-boh	
I don't want it	No lo/la quiero	noh loh/lah KYEH-roh	
Do you have a bag?	¿Tiene bolsa?	TYEH-neh BOHL-sah	
Can you gift wrap it?	¿Puede envolverlo para regalo?	PWEH-deh ehn-bohl-BEHR-loh PAH-rah rreh-GAH-loh	

9.2 Clothing Sizes

9.2.1 Size Words

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
size (clothing)	talla	TAH-yah
size (shoes)	número	NOO-meh-roh

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
small	pequeño/a	peh-KEH-nyoh/nyah
medium	mediano/a	meh-DYAH-noh/nah
large	grande	GRAHN-deh
extra large	extra grande	EHKS-trah GRAHN-deh

9.2.2 Trying On Clothes

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Can I try this on?	¿Puedo probármelo/la?	PWEH-doh proh-BAHR-meh-loh/lah	
Where are the fitting rooms?	¿Dónde están los probadores?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAHN lohs proh-bah-DOH-rehs	
It doesn't fit	No me queda bien	noh meh KEH-dah byehn	
It's too big	Me queda grande	meh KEH-dah GRAHN-deh	
It's too small	Me queda pequeño/a / chico/a	meh KEH-dah peh-KEH-nyoh	chico = LatAm
It's too tight	Me queda apretado/a	meh KEH-dah ah-preh-TAH-doh	
It's too loose	Me queda suelto/a	meh KEH-dah SWEHL-toh	
Do you have a bigger size?	¿Tiene una talla más grande?	TYEH-neh OO-nah TAH-yah mahs GRAHN-deh	
Do you have a smaller size?	¿Tiene una talla más pequeña?	TYEH-neh OO-nah TAH-yah mahs peh-KEH-nyah	
It fits perfectly	Me queda perfecto	meh KEH-dah pehr-FEHK-toh	
I'll try the other one	Voy a probar el otro / la otra	boy ah proh-BAHR ehl OH-troh / lah OH-trah	

9.3 Colors

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
black	negro	NEH-groh
white	blanco	BLAHN-koh
red	rojo	RROH-hoh
blue	azul	ah-SOOL
green	verde	BEHR-deh
yellow	amarillo	ah-mah-REE-yoh
orange	naranja	nah-RAHN-hah
pink	rosa / rosado	RROH-sah / rroh-SAH-doh
purple	morado / violeta	moh-RAH-doh / byoh-LEH-tah
brown	marrón / café	mah-RROHN / kah-FEH
grey	gris	grees
beige	beige	baysh
light (color)	claro	KLAH-roh
dark (color)	oscuro	ohs-KOO-roh

Usage: "Do you have it in blue?" = "¿Lo tiene en azul?"

9.4 Materials

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
cotton	algodón	ahl-goh-DOHN
wool	lana	LAH-nah
silk	seda	SEH-dah
linen	lino	LEE-noh
leather	cuero / piel	KWEH-roh / pyehl
synthetic	sintético	seen-TEH-tee-koh
denim	mezclilla / vaquero	mehs-KLEE-yah / bah-KEH-roh

9.5 Payment

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Where do I pay?	¿Dónde pago?	DOHN-deh PAH-goh	
I'll pay in cash	Pago en efectivo	PAH-goh ehn eh-fehk-TEE-boh	
I'll pay by card	Pago con tarjeta	PAH-goh kon tahr-HEH-tah	
Do you accept credit cards?	¿Aceptan tarjetas de crédito?	ah-SEHP-tahn tahr-HEH-tahs deh KREH-dee-toh	
Can I pay with my phone?	¿Puedo pagar con el móvil?	PWEH-doh pah-GAHR kon ehl MOH-beel	
Enter your PIN	Introduzca su PIN	een-troh-DOOS-kah soo peen	You may hear this
Sign here	Firme aquí	FEER-meh ah-KEE	
Do you give a discount for cash?	¿Hay descuento en efectivo?	eye dehs-KWEHN-toh ehn eh-fehk-TEE-boh	Common in Argentina
Is tax included?	¿Está incluido el IVA?	ehs-TAH een-kloo-EE-doh ehl EE-bah	IVA = sales tax

9.6 Returns and Exchanges

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I want to return this	Quiero devolver esto	KYEH-roh deh-bohl-BEHR EHS-toh	
I want to exchange this	Quiero cambiar esto	KYEH-roh kahm-BYAHR EHS-toh	
I have the receipt	Tengo el recibo / el ticket	TEHN-goh ehl rreh-SEE-boh / ehl TEE-keht	
It's defective	Está defectuoso/a	ehs-TAH deh-fehk-TWOH-soh	
It doesn't work	No funciona	noh foon-SYOH-nah	
Can I get a refund?	¿Puedo obtener un reembolso?	PWEH-doh ohb-teh-NEHR oon rreh-ehm-BOHL-soh	

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
What is the return policy?	¿Cuál es la política de devolución?	kwahl ehs lah poh-LEE-tee-kah deh deh-boh-loo-SYOHN	

9.7 Market and Bargaining

In traditional markets (mercados), bargaining is common in Latin America but less so in Spain.

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
How much for [item]?	¿Cuánto por [cosa]?	KWAHN-toh por [KO-sah]	Informal pricing
What's the best price?	¿Cuál es el mejor precio?	kwahl ehs ehl meh-HOR PREH-syoh	Opening to bargain
That's too expensive	Es muy caro	ehs mooy KAH-roh	
Can you lower the price?	¿Me puede hacer un descuento?	meh PWEH-deh ah-SEHR oon dehs-KWEHN-toh	Polite way to bargain
I'll give you [amount]	Le doy [cantidad]	leh doy [kahn-tee-DAHD]	Making a counter-offer
If I buy two?	¿Si compro dos?	see KOHM-proh dohs	Volume discount
Deal	¡Trato hecho!	TRAH-toh EH-choh	Agreeing on price
I'll think about it	Voy a pensarlo	boy ah pehn-SAHR-loh	Polite exit
Fresh today?	¿Es fresco/de hoy?	ehs FREHS-koh / deh oy	At food markets
Give me half a kilo	Deme medio kilo	DEH-meh MEH-dyoh KEE-loh	Produce markets
A bit more / a bit less	Un poco más / un poco menos	oon POH-koh mahs / oon POH-koh MEH-nohs	Adjusting quantity

9.8 Common Store Types

English	Spanish	Notes
pharmacy	farmacia	Green cross sign
bakery	panadería	
butcher	carnicería	
fish market	pescadería	
grocery store	tienda de alimentación / abarrotes (LatAm)	
supermarket	supermercado	
department store	grandes almacenes / tienda departamental	almacenes = Spain, departamental = LatAm
bookstore	librería	NOT library (biblioteca)
clothing store	tienda de ropa	
shoe store	zapatería	
electronics store	tienda de electrónica	
souvenir shop	tienda de recuerdos / souvenirs	

English	Spanish	Notes
tobacco shop	estanco (Spain)	Also sells transit cards, stamps
hardware store	ferretería	
market	mercado	
shopping center	centro comercial	

9.9 Shopping Hours by Region

Region	Typical Hours	Notes
Spain	10:00–14:00, 17:00–20:30	Many close for siesta. Large stores stay open.
Spain (large stores)	10:00–21:00 or 22:00	El Corte Inglés, shopping centers
Mexico	10:00–20:00 or later	Shopping centers open late
Argentina	10:00–20:00 (shops), 10:00–22:00 (malls)	Some close for lunch in smaller cities

10 Hotels and Accommodation

10.1 Accommodation Types

English	Spanish	Description
hotel	hotel	Standard hotel, star-rated (1–5 estrellas)
hostel	hostal (Spain) / hostel (LatAm)	Budget accommodation; hostal in Spain is a basic hotel (NOT a backpacker hostel)
backpacker hostel bed and breakfast	albergue juvenil pensión / casa de huéspedes	Shared dorms, social atmosphere Family-run, basic rooms
parador	parador	Spain: luxury hotel in historic building (castles, monasteries)
inn	posada	Small, traditional inn (common in LatAm)
vacation rental	alquiler vacacional / alojamiento	Airbnb-style
apartment	apartamento / departamento	apartamento = Spain, departamento = LatAm
cabin	cabaña	Mountain/rural areas
boutique hotel	hotel boutique	Trendy, design-focused

10.2 Booking and Reservations

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I have a reservation	Tengo una reserva	TEHN-goh OO-nah rreh-SEHR-bah	
I'd like to book a room	Quisiera reservar una habitación	kee-SYEH-rah rreh-sehr-BAHR OO-nah ah-bee-tah-SYOHN	
For [number] nights	Por [número] noches	por [NOO-meh-roh] NOH-chehs	
From [date] to [date]	Del [fecha] al [fecha]	dehl [FEH-chah] ahl [FEH-chah]	
How much per night?	¿Cuánto cuesta por noche?	KWAHN-toh KWEHS-tah por NOH-cheh	
Is breakfast included?	¿El desayuno está incluido?	ehl deh-sah-YOO-noh ehs-TAH een-kloo-EE-doh	
Is there Wi-Fi?	¿Hay Wi-Fi?	eye WAI-fai	
What's the Wi-Fi password?	¿Cuál es la contraseña del Wi-Fi?	kwahl ehs lah kohn-trah-SEH-nyah dehl WAI-fai	
Is there parking?	¿Hay aparcamiento/estacionamiento?	eye ah-pahr-kah-MYEHN-toh	aparcamiento = Spain
Do you have availability?	¿Tienen disponibilidad?	TYEH-nehn dees-poh-nee-bee-lee-DAHD	

10.3 Room Types

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
single room	habitación individual	ah-bee-tah-SYOHN een-dee-bee-DWAHL	
double room	habitación doble	ah-bee-tah-SYOHN DOH-bleh	
twin room	habitación con dos camas	ah-bee-tah-SYOHN kon dohs KAH-mahs	Two separate beds
suite	suite	sweet	
room with a view	habitación con vista	ah-bee-tah-SYOHN kon BEES-tah	
room with a balcony	habitación con balcón	ah-bee-tah-SYOHN kon bahl-KOHN	
non-smoking room	habitación de no fumadores	ah-bee-tah-SYOHN deh noh foo-mah-DOH-rehs	
accessible room	habitación accesible	ah-bee-tah-SYOHN ahk-seh-SEE-bleh	

10.4 Check-In

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I'm checking in	Vengo a registrarme / hacer el check-in	BEHN-goh ah rreh-hees-TRAHR-meh	
My name is [name]	Mi nombre es [nombre]	mee NOHM-breh ehs	

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Here's my passport	Aquí tiene mi pasaporte	ah-KEE TYEH-neh mee pah-sah-POHR-teh	
Here's my confirmation	Aquí tiene mi confirmación	ah-KEE TYEH-neh mee kohn-feer-mah-SYOHN	
What floor is the room on?	¿En qué piso/planta está la habitación?	ehn keh PEE-soh/PLAHN-tah ehs-TAH	piso = LatAm, planta = Spain
What time is check-out?	¿A qué hora es la salida?	ah keh OH-rah ehs lah sah-LEE-dah	
Can I have a late check-out?	¿Puedo hacer la salida más tarde?	PWEH-doh ah-SEHR lah sah-LEE-dah mahs TAHR-deh	
Where is the elevator?	¿Dónde está el ascensor/elevador?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH ehl ah-sehn-SOHR	ascensor = Spain
Where is the restaurant?	¿Dónde está el restaurante?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH ehl rrehs-tow-RAHN-teh	
What time is breakfast?	¿A qué hora es el desayuno?	ah keh OH-rah ehs ehl deh-sah-YOO-noh	

10.5 Check-Out

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
I'm checking out	Vengo a hacer el check-out / la salida	BEHN-goh ah ah-SEHR lah sah-LEE-dah	
Can I see the bill?	¿Puedo ver la cuenta?	PWEH-doh behr lah KWEHN-tah	
I think there's an error	Creo que hay un error	KREH-oh keh eye oon eh-RROHR	
I didn't use the minibar	No usé el minibar	noh oo-SEH ehl mee-nee-BAHR	
Can I leave my bags here?	¿Puedo dejar mi equipaje aquí?	PWEH-doh deh-HAHR mee eh-kee-PAH-heh ah-KEE	
Can you call a taxi?	¿Puede llamar un taxi?	PWEH-deh yah-MAHR oon TAHK-see	
It was a great stay	Fue una estancia muy agradable	fweh OO-nah ehs-TAHN-syah mooy ah-grah-DAH-bleh	

10.6 Requests and Room Issues

10.6.1 Common Requests

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Could I have extra towels?	¿Me puede dar toallas extra?	meh PWEH-deh dahr toh-AH-yahs EHKS-trah	
Could I have extra pillows?	¿Me puede dar almohadas extra?	meh PWEH-deh dahr ahl-moh-AH-dahs EHKS-trah	

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
Could I have extra blankets?	¿Me puede dar mantas extra?	meh PWEH-deh dahr MAHN-tahs EHKS-trah	
I need a wake-up call	Necesito que me despierten a las [hora]	neh-seh-SEE-toh keh meh dehs-PYEHR-tehn	
Can you clean the room?	¿Puede limpiar la habitación?	PWEH-deh leem-PYHR lah ah-bee-tah-SYOHN	
Please don't disturb	No molestar, por favor	noh moh-lehs-TAHR por fah-BOR	
I need an iron	Necesito una plancha	neh-seh-SEE-toh OO-nah PLAHN-chah	
Do you have a safe?	¿Tiene caja fuerte?	TYEH-neh KAH-hah FWEHR-teh	
I'd like to extend my stay	Quisiera extender mi estancia	kee-SYEH-rah ehks-tehn-DEHR mee ehs-TAHN-syah	
Can you recommend a restaurant?	¿Puede recomendarme un restaurante?	PWEH-deh rreh-koh-mehn-DAHR-meh	

10.6.2 Problems

English	Spanish	Pronunciation	Notes
The room is too noisy	La habitación tiene mucho ruido	lah ah-bee-tah-SYOHN TYEH-neh MOO-choh RREE-doh	
The air conditioning doesn't work	El aire acondicionado no funciona	ehl AY-reh ah-kohn-dee-syoh-NAH-doh noh foon-SYOH-nah	
The heating doesn't work	La calefacción no funciona	lah kah-leh-fahk-SYOHN noh foon-SYOH-nah	
The hot water isn't working	No hay agua caliente	noh eye AH-gwah kah-LYEHN-teh	
The shower isn't working	La ducha no funciona	lah DOO-chah noh foon-SYOH-nah	
The toilet is clogged	El inodoro está tapado/atascado	ehl ee-noh-DOH-roh ehs-TAH tah-PAH-doh	tapado = LatAm, atascado = Spain
There's no hot water	No hay agua caliente	noh eye AH-gwah kah-LYEHN-teh	
The TV doesn't work	La televisión no funciona	lah teh-leh-bee-SYOHN noh foon-SYOH-nah	
I'm locked out	Me quedé fuera de la habitación	meh keh-DEH FWEH-rah deh lah ah-bee-tah-SYOHN	
Can I change rooms?	¿Puedo cambiar de habitación?	PWEH-doh kahm-BYHR deh ah-bee-tah-SYOHN	
There are insects in the room	Hay insectos en la habitación	eye een-SEHK-tohs ehn lah ah-bee-tah-SYOHN	
It's too cold/hot	Hace mucho frío/calor	AH-seh MOO-choh FREE-oh/kah-LOHR	

10.7 Room Vocabulary

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
key	llave	YAH-beh
key card	tarjeta/llave de la habitación	tahr-HEH-tah
bed	cama	KAH-mah
pillow	almohada	ahl-moh-AH-dah
blanket	manta / cobija (LatAm)	MAHN-tah / koh-BEE-hah
sheet	sábana	SAH-bah-nah
towel	toalla	toh-AH-yah
bathroom	baño	BAH-nyoh
shower	ducha	DOO-chah
bathtub	bañera	bah-NYEH-rah
soap	jabón	hah-BOHN
shampoo	champú	chahm-POO
toilet paper	papel higiénico	pah-PEHL ee-HYEH-nee-koh
hair dryer	secador de pelo	seh-kah-DOHR deh PEH-loh
air conditioning	aire acondicionado	AY-reh ah-kohn-dee-syoh-NAH-doh
heating	calefacción	kah-leh-fahk-SYOHN
light	luz	loos
outlet/plug	enchufe	ehn-CHOO-feh
adapter	adaptador	ah-dahp-tah-DOHR
balcony	balcón	bahl-KOHN
window	ventana	behn-TAH-nah
curtains	cortinas	kohr-TEE-nahs
closet	armario (Spain) / clóset (LatAm)	ahr-MAH-ryoh / KLOH-seht

10.8 Floor Numbering

Important: In Spain and most of Latin America, the ground floor is called **planta baja** (ground floor), and what Americans call the “second floor” is the **primera planta** (first floor).

American English	Spain / LatAm	Spanish Term
1st floor (ground)	Planta baja (PB)	planta baja
2nd floor	1st floor (1°)	primera planta/piso
3rd floor	2nd floor (2°)	segunda planta/piso
4th floor	3rd floor (3°)	tercera planta/piso

Note: Some modern buildings in Latin America use American-style numbering, especially in newer developments.

11 Cultural Guide

11.1 Regional Overviews

11.1.1 Spain

Madrid Personality & Pace Madrid is Spain's vibrant capital — cosmopolitan, lively, and proud. Life revolves around social connection, with meals running long and evenings extending well past midnight. The city is direct, warm, and energetic.

Social Behaviors - Open and direct: Madrileños are friendly and not shy about expressing opinions - **Physical closeness:** Conversations happen at close distance; don't step back - **Two-kiss greeting:** Standard between women, and between men and women. Men shake hands with other men in most settings - **Punctuality flexible:** 15-30 minute delays are common for social events. Business meetings expect punctuality - **Loud is normal:** Animated conversations at high volume are not arguments — it's passion

Dining Culture - Late meals: Lunch 2:00–4:00 PM, dinner 9:00–11:00 PM - **Menú del día:** Excellent-value set lunch at most restaurants (usually 10–15 €) - **Tapas culture:** Order tapas at the bar; it's social, stand-up eating - **Bread always provided:** Usually free with meals - **Coffee after meals:** Café solo (espresso) is standard

Key Vocabulary - Vale = “OK” (used constantly) - Tío/Tía = “Dude” / “Girl” (casual address) - Mola = “Cool” (slang) - Caña = Small draft beer

Barcelona Personality & Pace Barcelona blends Catalan and Spanish identity. It's creative, Mediterranean, and proud of its distinct culture. Many locals speak **Catalan** as a first language, though everyone speaks Spanish too.

Social Behaviors - Bilingual: Signs and announcements often in Catalan first, then Spanish - **Mediterranean lifestyle:** Outdoors-focused, beach culture, late nights - **Catalan pride:** Respect for Catalan identity is appreciated - **International:** Very tourist-friendly, many English speakers

Dining Culture - Pa amb tomàquet: Bread rubbed with tomato — a Catalan staple - **Seafood:** Excellent seafood, especially in Barceloneta - **Vermouth hour:** “Hora del vermut” before lunch is a tradition - **Similar hours to Madrid** but slightly earlier meals

Useful Catalan Words - Bon dia = Good morning (Catalan) - Gràcies = Thank you (Catalan) - Si us plau = Please (Catalan) - Using even a word of Catalan is very appreciated

11.1.2 Mexico

Mexico City (CDMX) Personality & Pace One of the world's largest cities — bustling, culturally rich, and warm. Mexicans are known for exceptional hospitality and politeness. Communication is indirect; people avoid saying “no” directly.

Social Behaviors - Warm greetings: One cheek kiss between women, and between men and women. Handshake between men - **Formality matters:** Use “usted” with strangers, older people, and service providers - **Indirect communication:** “Ahorita” (right now) might mean “later” or “maybe.” “Mañana” can mean “sometime in the future” - **Family-centered:** Family is paramount; asking about family is welcome small talk - **Punctuality flexible:** Social events start late (30–60 minutes). Business meetings are more punctual

Dining Culture - Lunch is the main meal: La comida (2:00–4:00 PM) is the biggest meal of the day - **Street food is excellent:** Tacos, tamales, elotes from street vendors are safe and delicious - **Salsa always offered:** Usually multiple salsas; ask “¿pica?” (Is it spicy?) before committing - **Buen**

provecho: Said when food arrives or when passing people eating — like “bon appétit” - **Tortillas are bread**: Served with virtually every meal

Key Vocabulary - ¿Mande? = “What?” / “Pardon?” (very polite, Mexican) - Órale = “OK” / “Wow” / “Let’s go” (versatile) - Güey = “Dude” (extremely casual, only with friends) - Chido/Padre = “Cool” - Neta = “Really?” / “For real” - Fresa = “Posh/preppy”

Safety Tips - Use authorized taxis (pink/white in CDMX) or ride-hailing apps - Keep valuables concealed in crowded areas - Drink bottled water - Ask locals about neighborhoods before exploring at night

11.1.3 Argentina

Buenos Aires Personality & Pace Porteños (Buenos Aires residents) are expressive, intellectual, and passionate. Italian immigration deeply influenced the culture, food, and even the accent. Conversations are long, opinions are strong, and social life is rich.

Social Behaviors - One cheek kiss: Universal greeting for everyone — men to men, women to women, everyone. This is more physical than most countries - **Vos instead of tú**: Argentines use “vos” universally (¿Vos querés? instead of ¿Tú quieres?) - **Animated conversations**: Loud, passionate debates are entertainment, not conflict - **Late everything**: Dinner at 10:00 PM is normal, going out at midnight or 1:00 AM is standard - **Mate culture**: Sharing mate (yerba mate tea) is a bonding ritual. Accept if offered; decline politely if not your thing

Dining Culture - Asado (barbecue): The national obsession. Beef-centric cuisine is deeply cultural - **Late dinner**: 9:00–10:00 PM start, sometimes later - **Merienda**: Afternoon coffee/tea with pastries (medialunas = croissants) around 5:00–6:00 PM - **Facturas**: Pastries from the panadería (bakery) — a morning and merienda staple - **Wine**: Argentina is a major wine producer; Malbec is the signature grape

Key Vocabulary - Che = “Hey” (friendly address, like “buddy”) - Boludo/a = “Dude” (casual; can be friendly or rude depending on tone) - Bárbaro = “Great” / “Awesome” - Pibe/Piba = “Kid” / “Guy/Girl” - Re = Intensifier (“re lindo” = really pretty) - Birra = Beer (from Italian)

Vos Conjugation (Key Verbs)

Verb	Tú form	Vos form
to be	tú eres	vos sos
to have	tú tienes	vos tenés
to want	tú quieres	vos querés
to be able	tú puedes	vos podés
to come	tú vienes	vos venís
to go	tú vas	vos vas (same)

11.2 Etiquette Guide

11.2.1 Greetings

Situation	Spain	Mexico	Argentina
Meeting someone	Two cheek kisses (women, mixed gender)	One cheek kiss (women, mixed gender)	One cheek kiss (everyone)
Business meeting	Handshake	Handshake	Handshake (first), then kiss once established
Entering a shop	“Hola, buenos días”	“Buenos días”	“Hola” or “Buen día”
Leaving a shop	“Adiós” or “Hasta luego”	“Gracias, hasta luego”	“Chau” or “Hasta luego”

11.2.2 Dining Etiquette

Rule	Details
Wait to be seated	In nicer restaurants, wait at the entrance. In casual places and bars, find your own table.
Both hands on the table	Resting hands in your lap (American style) is considered slightly odd. Keep wrists on the table edge.
Don’t rush the waiter	In Spain especially, service is intentionally relaxed. The table is “yours” for the evening.
Splitting the bill	Common among friends, but less common on dates. One person often pays.
Compliments to the chef	“Estaba riquísimo” (It was delicious) is always appreciated.
“Buen provecho”	Say this when food arrives to your table, or when walking past people eating. Universal.

11.2.3 Gift Giving

Situation	What to Bring
Invited to someone’s home	Wine, dessert, or flowers
Flowers to avoid	Dahlias (Spain — funeral flower), yellow flowers (some LatAm — grief/betrayal)
Business gifts	Nice wine, quality chocolate, or something from your home country

11.2.4 Topics to Avoid

Topic	Why
Comparing countries negatively	“Mexico is cheaper than Spain” — don’t compare
Politics (unless invited)	Strong opinions exist; let locals bring it up
Calling all Spanish “Mexican”	Each country has distinct identity and pride
Bullfighting opinions	Polarizing in Spain; don’t assume everyone supports it
Falklands/Malvinas	Extremely sensitive topic in Argentina

Topic	Why
The Spanish Civil War	Sensitive historical topic in Spain

11.2.5 Safe Conversation Topics

- Food and local cuisine (always a winner)
- Football/soccer (universal passion — learn the local team)
- Travel and your experiences in their country
- Family (especially in Latin America)
- Music and festivals
- Asking for recommendations

11.3 Punctuality Norms

Context	Spain	Mexico	Argentina
Business meetings	On time	On time (5–10 min grace)	On time (10 min grace)
Social dinner at someone's home	15–30 min late is normal	30–60 min late is normal	30–60 min late is normal
Restaurant reservation	On time	On time	On time (10 min grace)
Party/gathering	30+ min late is fine	1+ hour late is normal	1+ hour late is normal

Rule of thumb: Be on time for business and reservations. For social events, arriving “on time” may mean you arrive before the host is ready.

11.4 Dining Hours

Meal	Spain	Mexico	Argentina
Breakfast	7:00–10:00	7:00–10:00	7:00–10:00
Lunch	2:00–4:00	1:30–4:00	12:00–2:00
Merienda (snack)	5:30–7:00	—	5:00–6:00
Dinner	9:00–11:00	7:00–9:00	9:00–11:00

11.5 Safety Guide

11.5.1 General Safety (All Spanish-Speaking Countries)

Tip	Details
Keep valuables concealed	Don't flash expensive phones or jewelry in crowded areas
Use hotel safe	Store passport, extra cash, and valuables
Carry copies	Keep photocopies of passport and important documents
Stay aware	Be alert in tourist areas, transit stations, and markets
Use ATMs inside banks	Avoid standalone street ATMs, especially at night
Drink bottled water	In most of Latin America. Tap water is safe in Spain

11.5.2 Emergency Numbers

Country	Police	Ambulance	General Emergency
Spain	091 (National), 092 (Local)	061	112 (all emergencies)
Mexico	911	911	911
Argentina	101 (Police), 107 (Ambulance)	107	911 (in Buenos Aires)
Colombia	123	123	123
Chile	133 (Police)	131	131/133
Peru	105 (Police)	116	105

11.5.3 Country-Specific Safety Notes

Spain - Very safe overall; pickpocketing is the main risk in tourist areas (Las Ramblas, Gran Vía, metro) - Watch for the “bracelet trick” and “petition signing” scams - Pharmacies (green cross) are available everywhere for minor health issues

Mexico - Use authorized transportation (Uber, DiDi, sitio taxis) - In Mexico City: avoid hailing random taxis on the street - Drink bottled water; avoid ice from unknown sources - Most tourist areas are very safe; ask locals about specific neighborhoods - Keep a low profile with valuables in crowded areas

Argentina - Buenos Aires is generally safe; be careful in La Boca (away from Caminito) and at night - “Express kidnappings” (secuestro exprés) are rare but worth knowing about — don’t resist - Inflation means cash handling can involve large bills; use cards when possible - Blue/parallel dollar exchange rate exists; understand the system before exchanging money

11.5.4 Useful Safety Phrases

English	Spanish	Pronunciation
Is this area safe?	¿Es segura esta zona?	ehs seh-GOO-rah EHS-tah SOH-nah
I don’t feel safe	No me siento seguro/a	noh meh SYEHN-toh seh-GOO-roh
Where is the nearest hospital?	¿Dónde está el hospital más cercano?	DOHN-deh ehs-TAH ehl ohs-pee-TAHL mahs sehr-KAH-noh
I need to call my embassy	Necesito llamar a mi embajada	neh-seh-SEE-toh yah-MAHR ah mee ehm-bah-HAH-dah
Please call the police	Por favor, llame a la policía	por fah-BOR YAH-meh ah lah poh-lee-SEE-ah
I’ve been robbed	Me han robado	meh ahn rroh-BAH-doh
Leave me alone	Déjeme en paz	DEH-heh-meh ehn pahs
I don’t want to buy anything	No quiero comprar nada	noh KYEH-roh kohm-PRAHR NAH-dah